1. The military. Despite the changes since 2008, the military remains very powerful and many former generals sit in parliament as part of the USDP. They retain control of the country's economic wealth.
2. The two multi-ethnic, multi-confessional parties. The USDP was set up by the military to contest the 2010 elections (which it won); the NLD acts as the primary opposition party. At least in theory (and until recently in practice), both have memberships that are multi-ethnic and multi-confessional. However, since 2011 both have increasingly only spoken for the Burman ethnic community (who are mostly Buddhist).
3. Ethnic regional parties. Many ethnic groups such as the Shan, Karen and Rakhine have set up parties that reflect their own specific interests. The key exception is, of course, the Rohingyas.
4. Buddhist monks. These have become increasingly important in the political arena since 1998. Among the extremists there are two main organisations, the 969 Movement and the MaBaTha (the Patriotic Association of Myanmar). Both are at the forefront of all moves to demonise Myanmar's Muslim minority and have been implicated in almost all the major episodes of inter-communal violence since 2010. However, there are other groups of Buddhist monks who have challenged these movements' interpretation of their faith and their intolerance.
5. Civil society groups. Groups such as Pan Zagar have called for an end to anti-Muslim hate speech, but they are weak.[58] Other groups have convinced the NLD to campaign against recent laws banning marriage between Buddhist women and Muslim men.[59]

It is useful to consider each of these in turn, and to draw attention to where they have close links.

The military

Before independence there had been a substantial debate between those like Aung San (the father of Aung San Suu Kyi) who argued that the military should be subordinate to the civil authorities,[60] and those like Ne Win who saw the military as the only reliable institution in an unstable multi-ethnic, multi-confessional state. Ne Win won (especially as Aung San was assassinated before independence) and by 1962 had taken power in a